ogled by men sitting on the backs of elephants in the street. He also made it clear he didn't intend spending very long in the town: as he put it in one letter to Ochterlony, 'What advantage have I in remaining here?'[25]

The Shah had many faults, but lack of energy or an excess of self-doubt were never among them. Undeterred by his defeats, from the first months of his enforced exile he began to make plans to raise another army to retake his throne, 'dreaming sweet dreams of re-conquering the Kingdom of Khurasan'. In his memoirs, he recounted how he took comfort in the example of previous monarchs who had lost their kingdoms only to regain larger dominions later in life: 'Amir Timur [Timurlane], among modern rulers, was twelve times driven from Samarkand,' he wrote, 'while among the ancients, Afrasyab fought Kai Khusro in seventy battles, was defeated over and again, but never gave up. In the same way [the Mughal Emperor] Humayun inherited the provinces of India, but was defeated by Sher Shah and was forced to flee and beg help from Shah 'Abbas Safavi in Iran. In truth, unless God wills it, nothing will succeed. But when God wills it, we shall surely be successful.'[26]

At this time, Shah Shuja tended to swing wildly between excitement, self-delusion and depression. One day he would dream up what Ochterlony described as 'altogether visionary' plans to surprise his adversaries by returning to Afghanistan via 'the snowy mountains and Thibet'.[27] The next, he would sink into gloom as the impracticality of his schemes became obvious. 'The mind of the Shah remains in an unsettled and restless state,' wrote one Ludhiana officer, 'and he often observes that inactivity and want of employment ill-accord with the tenor of his disposition.' The officer added:

> It has been and will be a part of my duty to soothe, as much as possible, the troubled breast of the Shah . . . I use every persuasive argument that suggests itself to me to dissuade him from entertaining notions that cannot be gratified, such as that of getting British assistance for the recovery of his Throne, the wish of proceeding to Calcutta, or a strong desire to reside at some other post within the British territories. I have even delicately told the Shah's advisers, that these proceed from an unsettled mind and that no place but Kabul would ever be found fully to answer the Shah's expectations.[28]

Nonetheless, only a year after his arrival, concrete plans were in place, and anxious reports began to reach Calcutta about the number of cavalrymen descending on Ludhiana to seek service with the Shah. The government sent back pleas to Ochterlony that 'His Majesty should be induced to